

STARTER

Field-by-Field Application Walkthrough

United States - F-1 Student Visa: from your I-20 to your interview

VERIFY BEFORE YOU APPLY

Fees, forms, and processing times change without notice. This guide reflects publicly documented procedures as commonly published; treat every dollar figure, form number, and timeline here as a starting point, and confirm the current version on the official government site before you submit anything or pay any fee.

Before you start: the I-20 comes first

Unlike a tourist visa, you can't begin an F-1 application until your SEVP-approved school has issued you a Form I-20, Certificate of Eligibility for Nonimmigrant Student Status - generated in SEVIS (the Student and Exchange Visitor Information System) once you're admitted and have shown the school evidence of funding. Everything else in this pack assumes you already have your signed I-20 in hand.

THE I-20's FINANCIAL FIGURE IS YOUR REFERENCE AMOUNT

There's no government-set minimum for an F-1 application - your own school sets the annual cost figure on your I-20 (tuition plus estimated living expenses), and that figure is what you need to evidence funding against, not a fixed number from immigration authorities. See the Financial Requirements Overview (Essential tier).

Gather before you begin

- Valid passport, valid for at least 6 months beyond your intended stay
- Your signed Form I-20 from your SEVP-approved school
- Proof of payment of the SEVIS I-901 fee - paid separately, before your interview
- A completed DS-160 online nonimmigrant visa application, with its confirmation page
- A visa application fee (MRV fee) payment receipt
- Financial evidence matching your I-20's stated cost figure
- Academic documents: transcripts, diplomas, test scores used for admission
- Evidence of your intent to return home after your studies

Section-by-section

1. Complete the DS-160

An online form covering your personal details, travel plans, and SEVIS ID (found on your I-20) - printed confirmation page is required at your interview.

2. Pay the SEVIS I-901 fee

A separate fee from the visa application fee, paid online and tied to your SEVIS ID - keep the payment receipt, since it's checked at your interview.

3. Book your interview

At the US embassy or consulate with jurisdiction over your location - availability varies significantly by post and season, so book as early as your I-20 allows.

4. Prepare your financial evidence

Matching the figure on your I-20 - see the Financial Requirements Overview for what counts and how sponsors and assistantships fit in.

5. Attend your interview

A consular officer decides your case, generally the same day, based on your documents and the interview itself - see the Visa Interview Appointment Checklist (Complete tier).

6. Mind the entry-timing rules

Your F-1 visa can't be issued more than 120 days before your I-20's program start date, and you can't enter the US more than 30 days before that same start date - plan your interview and travel accordingly.